



ERIN SCHAFF/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Rescued wild horses at Oregon’s Skydog Ranch. Government sales of horses were once rare, but started to rise under President Trump.

Loophole Leads to the Slaughter of Protected Wild Horses

By DAVE PHILIPPS

They once had run free through the desert mountains of the West, a multicolored band of 68 wild mustangs that had never been saddled or corralled.

Then the federal government rounded them up with helicopters, as it has with tens of thousands of other mustangs, in an attempt to control wild populations on public lands. The horses were held for years in a feed lot in Idaho while the government tried to find them what it called “loving homes.”

Abruptly this March, the government found a home. Whether it was loving didn’t seem to matter.

The horses were packed into echoing metal trailers and trucked 1,800 miles east to the pens of a hard-luck livestock trader in Ohio named Brandon Jones, who bought them for \$25 each.

A day later, two double-decker cattle trucks pulled up at midnight, loaded the mustangs and quickly drove off into the night.

From there the mustangs disappeared. They never appeared at a public auction. The trader won’t say where they went. Wild horse advocates suspect the horses were shipped to slaughter.

But that’s not the government’s concern — it got what it wanted:

U.S. Sells Mustangs for as Low as \$25 Each to Attract Buyers

two more trucks of wild horses off its books.

It wasn’t the first time, or the last. In the past year, the government has shipped the trader one truckload of mustangs after another. And not just him.

An examination of government records by The New York Times found that all over the country the Bureau of Land Management, the

agency in charge of protecting wild horses, is quietly selling thousands of horses to buyers like the one in Ohio. Slaughtering wild horses is illegal, but the bureau’s actions create a loophole that enables people to get mustangs on the cheap and then quickly resell them to be exported alive, processed into cuts of meat and sold abroad.

Livestock inspection records show mustangs sold by the government soon ended up on trucks bound for slaughter plants in Canada.

The U.S. government’s sales of wild horses were once rare, but

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Administration Tries New Ways To Hit Harvard

By MARK ARSENAULT and IRENA HWANG

One of Harvard University’s biggest federal funding streams is down sharply, according to a New York Times analysis of government data.

The declines have persisted even after a federal judge forced the Trump administration to reverse drastic cuts to the university last year.

The funding, from the National Institutes of Health, currently lags about 18 percent behind the average pace of grants during the Biden administration, the analysis shows.

Last year, Harvard successfully sued the Trump administration, after the government announced it had frozen more than \$2.2 billion in 2025, from multiple federal agencies.

But unlike then, when Trump officials made a public spectacle out of announcing the cuts, the N.I.H. is mainly delaying, reducing or rejecting grant requests, often leaving researchers and university leaders in the dark about what is happening.

The reduction appears to be the latest front in the Trump administration’s on-again, off-again war with Harvard and other elite universities. It is a new, more subtle tactic that is harder to fight in court, but that could be just as

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KARSTEN MORAN FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The tax on high-end second homes was seen as a way to help New York City close a budget gap.

Bumpy Rollout Hurts Mamdani’s 2nd-Home Tax

This article is by Mihir Zaveri, Sally Goldenberg, Benjamin Oreskes and Grace Ashford.

Gov. Kathy Hochul had resisted pressure from the left to raise taxes as she ran for re-election this year, before agreeing to a compromise: a tax on high-end second homes in New York City. The move would secure desperately needed revenue and deliver a win to her ally Mayor Zohran Mamdani.

Opportunity for Critics and Court Fights

But what appeared to be a comfortable resolution soon turned into a quagmire, with business leaders feeling vilified by the city’s introduction of the tax and some homeowners confused and outraged after being told they might have to pay — reactions

that troubled Ms. Hochul.

“The rollout could’ve been better,” Ms. Hochul said in an interview this week, recounting a conversation she had with Mr. Mamdani earlier this summer. “Absolutely, I said the rollout has to be cleaned up and fixed.”

Ms. Hochul, was concerned about what she saw as clumsy messaging by Mr. Mamdani as he introduced the esoteric tax to New Yorkers. She told the mayor that

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Trump Lawsuit Would Target Critical Report

Latest Intimidation Bid Aims at Think Tank

By ALAN FEUER

President Trump has opened a new front in his campaign to intimidate political foes, threatening a prominent liberal think tank with a \$5 billion defamation lawsuit over a report concluding that his deployment of the National Guard to cities across the country has had little effect on reducing violent crime.

The threats against the think tank, the Center for American Progress, were Mr. Trump’s latest effort to use the legal system to punish critics for voicing unflattering facts and opinions generally protected by the First Amendment. And while it is unclear how far any suit the president might ultimately file will get in court, it could force the organization to spend money fighting it off and make it even more of a target of his allies and supporters.

On Monday, one of Mr. Trump’s personal lawyers, Alejandro Brito, wrote a letter to the center warning that he would file the suit if the group did not fully retract the report, which was published on its website on July 13. The letter, viewed by The New York Times, was addressed to the group’s president and chief executive, Neera Tanden, a longtime Democratic official who served as a senior adviser to President Joseph R. Biden Jr., and to several of its board members.

Mr. Brito claimed that the report about the National Guard was full of malicious and false statements. He gave Ms. Tanden and members of her board until 5 p.m. on Friday to retract it and apologize to Mr. Trump.

Ms. Tanden pushed back, saying in a statement that the center would “neither cower nor bend in the face” of legal action. She also defended the report, asserting that while its findings might have been “inconvenient to the Trump administration,” they were “grounded in rigorous, evidence-

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THE WEATHER

Today, cloudy, rain, light wind, high 75. Tonight, thunderstorms, cloudy, low 68. Tomorrow, partly cloudy, humid, showers and thunderstorms, high 80. Weather map, Page A20.

Why Beijing Bets Trump Blinks First

China Ready for Risk in Iran Sanctions

By DAVID PIERSON and BERRY WANG

HONG KONG — As Iran’s largest trading partner, China would seemingly have much to lose from President Trump’s threat this week to impose “tremendous economic consequences” on nations doing business with Tehran.

For decades, China has defied Western sanctions on Iranian oil by buying up to 90 percent of Tehran’s oil exports. China has also supplied Iran with technology and raw materials to build an arsenal of missiles and drones.

But Beijing has reasons to feel confident it can withstand Mr. Trump’s latest warning — if it is ever fulfilled. And increasingly, Chinese analysts see the war in Iran, which the White House seems unable to end on favorable terms, as a sign of America’s mounting weakness.

“This threat reveals how desperate the Trump administration has become on the issue of Iran,” said Wu Xinbo, a leading American studies scholar at Fudan University in Shanghai, who advises China’s foreign ministry.

“They issue this threat not because they think it is workable,” he said, “but because they have no other options” to get out of this “self-created dilemma.”

In a social media post on Wednesday, Mr. Trump vowed to inflict an “economic D-Day” on Iran, as well as to punish countries that “provide any type of lifeline” to the country. On Thursday, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent implied that it was in China’s best interest to cooperate.

But China might be feeling emboldened as the United States withdraws military assets in the Pacific that were largely meant

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CONGRESS IGNORED The White House has failed to disclose a document assessing foreign meddling in the 2024 election. **PAGE A13**

PROJECT PROCEEDS The Supreme Court temporarily allowed President Trump to continue construction on a White House ballroom. **PAGE A13**

At 77, She Walked From ‘Hell’ For Miles Under Hostile Skies

By CASSANDRA VINOGRAD and OLEKSANDR CHUBKO

SLOVIANSK, Ukraine — Stay, or try to escape? Nina Ivanova, 77, felt the odds of survival were 50/50 either way, and she had nothing left to lose.

Russian forces were just over a mile away, battering her city, Lyman, in eastern Ukraine, with glide bombs and drones. Her husband was dead after a long illness, and her home was destroyed. She was hiding in a basement with her two daughters.

Lyman was burning, but civilian and military evacuation teams no longer entered the city, given the danger. The only way out was on foot — nine miles under drone-filled skies.

When Ms. Ivanova saw a body eaten by dogs in Lyman, it helped push her to her limit, she said. She and her daughters would take their chances on the road, as countless Ukrainians have done before them all along the front line.

“We got up and left,” she said.

Ms. Ivanova and her husband, Borys, lived in Lyman for decades. They raised their children there, in a house on Michurina Street.



CASSANDRA VINOGRAD/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Nina Ivanova set out to flee Lyman, Ukraine, and drones.

The city, which had a prewar population of 20,000, served as a rail hub for the Donbas region. When Russia invaded Ukraine in February 2022, seizing the Donbas was a central aim, and that made Lyman a prime target.

Russian forces fought their way through dense forests and fields surrounding Lyman and seized the city in May 2022. Ukrainian troops drove them out five months later. But Lyman was never fully free of Russian fire.

Over time, Moscow’s small advances toward the city began to add up, and strikes on Lyman

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BUSINESS B1-5

New Coaster, Loud Guests

Universal built a “whisper quiet” ride to avoid angering neighbors. It did not account for riders’ reactions. **PAGE B5**

Higher Rates Could Pose Risks

A period of rapid readjustment is ahead for the world’s largest economy and most important financial system. **PAGE B1**

NATIONAL A9-16, 20

Evidence of Double-Billing

For years, Jessica Ramos, a New York senator, used campaign funds to pay for travel while also receiving state payments, records show. **PAGE A15**

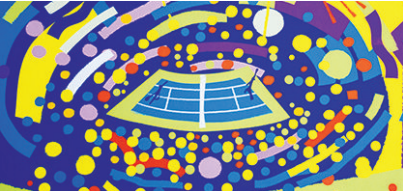
Crushing Climate Policies

The Trump administration is pulling out all stops to stifle California’s environmental protection efforts. **PAGE A9**

OBITUARIES A17

New York’s ‘Hip-Hop Cop’

Derrick Parker, a veteran detective, was a one-man intelligence unit and liaison to the music world. He was 65.



ARTS C1-6

Tennis Poster Has City Vibes

Eugenia Mello created art for the 2026 U.S. Open inspired by movement, color and her immigrant experience. **PAGE C1**

Exploring a Comic Mystery

In the TV series ‘Diarra From Detroit,’ Diarra Kilpatrick, the creator and star, shares a city’s ‘little treasures.’ **PAGE C1**

INTERNATIONAL A4-8

Orban’s Office, Thrown Open

The new government of Peter Magyar of Hungary hoped to use the suite overlooking the Danube as evidence of an autocrat’s indulgence. The trappings, however, fell short. **PAGE A5**

Training A.I. on Human Jobs

In the fast-growing field of data annotation, workers in a small city in southern India are helping A.I. to improve how it performs tasks that are traditionally done by people. **PAGE A4**

OPINION A18-19

Christine Emba **PAGE A19**



SPORTS B6-8

Hang a Left at the Archives

At this weekend’s Freedom 250 Grand Prix, IndyCars will race 175 miles per hour through D.C. streets where the speed limit is usually 25. **PAGE B6**



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